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SIBAL IN A MEETING WITH REPRESENTATIVES OF THE IIT FACULTY

Valley's Shailesh Shirali and Kapur.

It's a tradition he follows for everything. Pramod Kapoor, Roli Books, who published his book of sms poems, *i witness*, recalls it was the nature of meetings he would have to plan his book as well. "We knew the book would work because he is such a great seller." It's education he is now promoting, as its self-styled brand ambassador and most high profile publicist. He believes he has started a national debate on it. As he puts it: "Education is at the forefront of the country's agenda. It has been in the news like never before." As for not all his announcements being translated into action, he says aggressively: "The media thinks that if I take a decision, it will be implemented tomorrow. There are interministerial consultations, ministries will make some comments. If I make changes, it has to go again for interministerial consultations, then it has to go to the Cabinet, then it has to be introduced in Parliament, then it goes to the Standing Committee, then it is discussed in the Cabinet again and a final decision is taken."

Sibal, two-time Chandni Chowk MP, has always been an achiever, going from St Stephen's to Harvard Law School to being a successful lawyer and being called into Parliament to defend Supreme Court judge V. Ramaswami in his impeachment proceedings, something he considers a high watermark in his career. His political career is no surprise to his friends who always found him discussing politics intensely at south Delhi socialite evenings. And Govinda, who has watched him closely, says he is committed to bringing about fundamental change and devotes all his time to the portfolio, rather than to politics. But perhaps Sibal is slowly realising that it's a "tough struggle". "I can put some building blocks in place for others to build on. But to say that I have achieved this or that is really asking for the moon," he says. Going by recent experience though, it should not stop him. ■

Education Providers Bill. He sees himself as a reformer, a man who can leave a mark on a ministry that was hostage to politics for the last two terms, first by Murli Manohar Joshi's revisionism and then Arjun Singh's quota politics. Many elements of his new vision of making India the hub of education in the world are of high utility but they are also out of line in undermining the autonomy of the IIT Council and the CBSE which should have announced decisions dealing with their domains. It's a larger question of governance.

That is something Sibal insists he is making more democratic, with his roundtables. On higher education, his panel comprises Orissa University Vice-Chancellor Surabhi Bannerjee, former Britannia MD Sunil Alagh, CSIR Director General Samir K. Brahmachari, Planning Commission Member Narendra Jadhav, NIT Co-Chairman Rajendra S. Pawar, former Union secretary Rajeeva Ratna Shah and former UGC chairman Sukhdeo Thorat, among others. On school education, his panel consists of former secretary Anil Bordia, former Delhi Public School principal Shyama Chona, NUEPA Acting Vice-Chancellor R. Govinda, Rampal, NCERT Chairman Krishna Kumar, Rishi

DECLARE AND WITHDRAW

Sibal is always in the news, as are his decisions

Sibal announced that the HRD Ministry would be working towards a consensus on making Class X boards optional.

He had to specify later that he meant only CBSE schools.

He suggested raising the cut-off percentage for entry to IITs from 60 to 80 per cent.

He had to reiterate that he did not want to pre-empt the IIT Council decision or the panel formed to report on coaching institutes.

The minister piloted The Right of Children to Free and Compulsory Education Bill.

He failed to provide its financial implications to the states.

The ministry issued an order on the IIT teaching staff salary structure.

He had to agree to be "flexible on certain issues" like promotions and appointments.